3.1 Federalists and Antifederalists

Sometimes a fight between two people can spread until everyone takes a side. After the Constitutional Convention, citizens in the new nation faced this situation as two separate groups argued that their ideal vision was the right one.

MAIN IDEA Americans with opposite views about a strong central government engaged in intense debates over the ratification of the Constitution.

DIFFERENT POINTS OF VIEW

September 17, 1787, was a big day for the new United States. It was the day its Framers signed the Constitution. However, after it was signed, much more work was yet to come. Every state legislature had to ratify this new document. Given the spirited debates at the Constitutional Convention itself, it is not surprising that legislators and citizens quickly split into two factions. Those who supported the Constitution as it was written were known as **federalists**. Those who opposed all or parts of the Constitution were called **antifederalists**.

As you have read, federalism is a principle of governing in which a strong national government shares powers with the states. Federalists tended to live in big coastal cities and work in commerce. They hoped for more international trade and wanted to establish a strong and stable federal government. Some federalists were also frontier settlers, and they believed a strong central government could help defend them against attacks by Native Americans.

Antifederalists believed the Constitution did not provide strong enough barriers against the potential abuse of power by the federal government. They favored giving more power to state governments and believed only a government closest to the people could properly protect their liberties. Antifederalists tended to be from more rural areas, and they perceived the federal government as distant and separate from their interests. Antifederalists Patrick Henry and **George Mason**, a delegate from Virginia, gave impassioned speeches criticizing the Constitution.

Many newspapers supported the federalist cause. In New York, James Madison, Alexander Hamilton, and **John Jay**, who had been working behind the scenes in helping to craft the new government, published a series of essays in newspapers that argued in favor of the Constitution. In the spring of 1788, they published a book of the 85 essays called ***The Federalist***. Despite these convincing essays, some key states, such as North Carolina, Virginia, and New York, resisted ratification at first.

RATIFYING THE CONSTITUTION

Each state held a convention to debate and vote on the Constitution. Delaware was the first to ratify, followed by Pennsylvania, New Jersey, Georgia, Connecticut, and Massachusetts. Except for Pennsylvania, all these states had small populations. Delegates to conventions in these states understood the advantages of joining a union in which their representation was equal to that of larger states. In Pennsylvania, federalists led by James Wilson moved quickly to secure ratification before antifederalists in the rural west could organize.

Many state constitutions already included a bill of rights, and the federalists argued that for this reason, another bill of rights was unnecessary. But in Virginia, antifederalists George Mason and Patrick Henry argued that adding a bill of rights to the Constitution was necessary to protect individuals and states and to prevent abuse of power by the federal government. Political writer Mercy Otis Warren also advocated for a bill of rights. In 1788, horrified by the violence she witnessed during Shays's Rebellion, she argued that the revolutionaries did not fight against Britain only to meet with more tyranny.

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.



CRITICAL VIEWING In 1939, Congress commissioned artist Howard Chandler Christy to paint *Signing of the Constitution* in honor of the 150-year anniversary of the Constitution. It is an enormous work, 20 by 30 feet in size, and it hangs in the House wing of the U.S. Capitol. In this painting, Christy depicts the events of September 17, 1787.

George Washington stands in front of his Rising Sun chair during the signing, which was held at Independence Hall. The 81-year-old Ben Franklin listens to something Alexander Hamilton is telling him, and Richard Spaight signs the document. How does this painting convey the importance of the event it depicts?

By July 1788, all but two states—North Carolina and Rhode Island—had voted for ratification. Rhode Island, again a holdout, refused to ratify the Constitution until a list of changes was included. The vote for ratification was so close that James Madison finally proposed to Congress that a set of 12 official **amendments**, or changes, be added to the Constitution to provide greater constitutional protection for individual liberties. The states ratified 10 of these amendments, and Congress added them to the Constitution. These amendments, which place specific restrictions on governmental power, became known as the **Bill of Rights**. Together, the Constitution and the Bill of Rights have provided the foundation for the U.S. government for more than 200 years.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What were the main arguments between the federalists and the antifederalists?
2. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** What are some general characteristics of the people who identified as federalists and those who identified as antifederalists?
3. **DESCRIBE** Why did Congress add the Bill of Rights to the Constitution?

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.